



STUDY GUIDE • IEUMUN 2026

UNODC

United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime

Combating Human Trafficking in Conflict & Post-Conflict Zones

CHAIRS

Julia, Roshni & Francesca

Contents

01	Chair Letter	3
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02	List of Abbreviations	5
----	------------------------------	---

03	About the Committee	6
----	----------------------------	---

	History of the Committee	6
--	--------------------------	---

	Mandate of the UNODC	7
--	----------------------	---

04	Topic	9
----	--------------	---

	Introduction to the topic	9
--	---------------------------	---

	Historical Background	10
--	-----------------------	----

	Past Actions	11
--	--------------	----

	Current Situation and Statistics	14
--	----------------------------------	----

	Problem Statement	18
--	-------------------	----

	Bloc Positions	19
--	----------------	----

	Key Stakeholders	23
--	------------------	----

	Guiding Questions - QARMAs	24
--	----------------------------	----

	Bibliography	26
--	---------------------	----

	Further Reading	28
--	------------------------	----

01

Chair Letter

A LETTER FROM

Julia, Roshni and Francesca

Dear distinguished delegates,

It is a great honour for us to host you for the IE University Model United Nations (IEUMUN) as your Chairs for the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime.

Hi, our names are Julia, Roshni, and Francesca, and we'll be your Chairs for this committee.

Julia is a third-year student at Leiden University pursuing a Bachelor of International Relations and Organisations; her passion for Model UN began at the real UNODC Youth Forum in 2023 in Vienna, where she represented the Russian Federation and served as a final statement speaker before the 66th Commission on Narcotic Drugs, and being a UNODC Chair now holds deep symbolic meaning for her. Roshni is currently pursuing a Bachelor of Business Administration with a major in Finance at Hult International Business School, and Model United Nations has become one of her greatest passions in recent years, helping her develop her leadership, diplomacy, and public speaking skills. Francesca studies International Relations and International Law at the University of Edinburgh, Scotland, and is deeply passionate about how our world operates and how power rebalances through conflict and its impact on innocent civilian lives. Together, we hope to create a committee that is engaging, respectful, and intellectually stimulating, where every delegate feels encouraged to participate, think critically, and explore these topics with us through thoughtful and conscientious discussion.

We've noticed that many experienced delegates tend to just skim through background guides in their entirety, but for those just beginning their MUN journey, this approach doesn't work as well - a study guide is meant to be your kickstart point for deeper research, not a shortcut past it.

You will have to learn and understand the game: the logic, the performance, and the careful act of balancing public statements and backchannel diplomacy. Eventually, you may find that the debates and preparation tend to blur together. No. That is not so. Therefore, if you are reading this letter - well done. You may already be one step ahead. And if you are not reading this letter, well, bear the challenge. Game on.

We would now like to reiterate the importance of content and bloc positions. Your words and actions should clearly reflect your state's foreign policy and beyond that, there should exist little fluff in your speeches. As well, we encourage you to take risks. Raise your placard when nobody else dares to speak. Anyone can speak. Influence comes from those who know how to convey the meaning. Good luck to all delegates!

We look forward to meeting you!

Yours sincerely,

Julia, Roshni and Francesca

02

List of Abbreviations

UNODC	United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime
UNHCR	United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees
TOC	Transnational Organized Crime
UNTOC	United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime
TIP	Protocol (Palermo Protocol) - Core international anti-trafficking treaty
CND	Commission on Narcotic Drugs
IDP	Internally Displaced Person
DDR	Disarmament, Demobilization, and Reintegration
IOM	International Organization for Migration
CRSV	Conflict-Related Sexual Violence
UASC	Unaccompanied and Separated Children
IO	International Organisation
NGO	Non-governmental Organisation
IRC	International Rescue Committee

03

About the Committee

History of the Committee

UNODC was established in 1997, formed through the merger of the United Nations International Drug Control Programme (UNDCP), created in 1991, and the Crime Prevention and Criminal Justice Division of the United Nations Office at Vienna, established in 1992. It was originally named the Office for Drug Control and Crime Prevention and adopted its current name in 2002 to reflect its broadened scope.¹

Since its founding, UNODC's mandate has expanded considerably beyond drug control, shaped by a series of landmark developments:

Year	Event
1997	Establishment of the Office for Drug Control and Crime Prevention through the merger of UNDCP and the Crime Prevention and Criminal Justice Division.
2000	Adoption of the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (UNTOC) in Palermo, together with the supplementing Protocol to Prevent, Suppress and Punish Trafficking in Persons, Especially Women and Children. This is the primary legal instrument underpinning this Committee's mandate on trafficking. ²
2002	The Office adopted its current name, the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, reflecting its widened focus on organised crime alongside drug control.
2003	Adoption of the United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC), for which UNODC also serves as guardian and secretariat.

¹ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, "About UNODC" (UNODC, no date) <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/about-unodc/index.html>

- 2016-201 The Security Council formally linked human trafficking to armed conflict and terrorism for the first time through Resolution 2331 (2016), reinforced by Resolution 2388 (2017), both calling on UNODC and member states to strengthen victim identification, prosecution and cross-border cooperation in conflict-affected regions.^{3 4}
- 2010-20 Leadership of the Office has reflected its growing international profile: Yuri Fedotov served as Executive Director from 2010 to 2019, followed by Ghada Fathi Waly of Egypt from 2020 to 2026. On 11 May 2026, Monica Juma of Kenya assumed office as Executive Director of UNODC and Director-General of the United Nations Office at Vienna, becoming the most senior Kenyan official in United Nations history.⁵

Mandate of the UNODC

The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) is the entity within the UN Secretariat mandated to assist member states in their struggle against illicit drugs, transnational organised crime, corruption and terrorism in all their forms and manifestations. Its mission, in line with the current UNODC Strategy, is to contribute to global peace and security, human rights and development by making the world safer from drugs, crime and terrorism, working for and with member states to promote justice, the rule of law and resilient societies.⁶

UNODC pursues this mission through three interlocking pillars of work:

- **Research and analysis:** producing evidence-based knowledge products, such as the annual Global Report on Trafficking in Persons and the World Drug Report, which inform policy-making at the national and international level.

² United Nations General Assembly, "United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime" (res 55/25, 15 November 2000). The text of the Convention and Protocol is available via UNODC: <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/organized-crime/intro/UNTOC.html>

³ United Nations Security Council, Resolution 2331 (2016), S/RES/2331 (20 December 2016) <https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/s/res/2331-%282016%29>

⁴ United Nations Security Council, Resolution 2388 (2017), S/RES/2388 (21 November 2017) <https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/content/sres2388-2017>

⁵ United Nations, "Secretary-General Appoints Monica Juma of Kenya Executive Director, United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime" (UN Press Release, 2026). The specific press release should be available at <https://press.un.org>

⁶ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, UNODC Strategy 2021–2025 (Vienna: UNODC, 2021) <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/strategy/index.html>

- **Normative work:** acting as guardian of, and secretariat to, the treaty bodies overseeing the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (UNTOC) and its supplementing Protocols, including the Palermo Protocol on trafficking in persons, as well as the United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC) and the three international drug control conventions.
- **Technical assistance and capacity-building:** training law enforcement, judicial and border officials, supporting legislative reform, and strengthening victim identification and protection systems, particularly in states with limited institutional capacity.⁷

As a specialised, non-enforcement body of the UN Secretariat, UNODC's mandate is exercised through cooperation, technical support and normative guidance rather than binding enforcement measures. Delegates should therefore frame resolutions around treaty implementation, institutional capacity-building, information-sharing and victim protection, rather than measures, such as sanctions or peacekeeping deployment, that fall outside the Committee's competence.

Because trafficking in persons frequently overlaps with organised crime, terrorism financing and conflict dynamics, UNODC exercises this mandate in close coordination with other UN entities, including UNHCR, IOM and UNICEF, as well as with the Security Council when trafficking intersects with threats to international peace and security.⁸

⁷ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, UNODC Strategy 2021–2025 (Vienna: UNODC, 2021) <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/strategy/index.html>

⁸ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024 (Vienna: UNODC, 2024) <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/data-and-analysis/glotip.html>

04

Topic

Introduction to the topic

Human trafficking is one of the most pervasive transnational crimes in the world, and conflict and post-conflict zones have become some of the most vulnerable environments in which it operates. Armed conflict weakens governing institutions, displaces populations on a mass scale, and disrupts economies, creating conditions in which criminal networks can act with relative impunity. Refugees and internally displaced persons are especially vulnerable, as they often lack documentation, stable housing, employment and access to legal protection, conditions traffickers exploit through deceptive job offers, fraudulent transportation arrangements and false promises of safety.⁹

A distinguishing feature of trafficking in conflict settings, compared to trafficking in stable states, is the direct involvement of armed actors. Non-state armed groups and terrorist organisations have used trafficking not only as a source of revenue but as an instrument of warfare, employing forced marriage, sexual slavery, forced labour and the recruitment of child soldiers to sustain operations and exert control over civilian populations. This reality was formally recognised by the Security Council in 2016 through Resolution 2331, the first resolution to explicitly link trafficking in persons to armed conflict and terrorism.¹⁰

Because trafficking in conflict zones sits at the intersection of humanitarian protection, criminal justice and international peace and security, addressing it requires coordination between UNODC, humanitarian actors such as UNHCR and IOM, peacekeeping missions, and the national authorities of source, transit and destination states, the same set of actors examined throughout this guide.

⁹ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024 (Vienna: UNODC, 2024) <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/data-and-analysis/glotip.html>

¹⁰ United Nations Security Council, Resolution 2331 (2016), S/RES/2331 (20 December 2016) <https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/s/res/2331-%282016%29>

Historical Background

International concern over trafficking dates back over a century, though its legal definition and its connection to armed conflict have evolved considerably over time.

- **Early international efforts (1904–1949)** International concern over trafficking, then framed as the “trafficking of women and children” or “white slave traffic,” began with the 1904 International Agreement for the Suppression of the White Slave Traffic, followed by further conventions in 1910, 1921 and 1933. These efforts culminated in the 1949 UN Convention for the Suppression of the Traffic in Persons and of the Exploitation of the Prostitution of Others, the first comprehensive international instrument on the issue, though it lacked a clear, universally accepted definition of trafficking.
- **Cold War and regional conflicts (1950s–1990s).** Trafficking connected to conflict was documented but rarely addressed as a distinct international priority during this period. The wars in the Balkans during the 1990s, however, drew significant international attention to the link between armed conflict, mass displacement and sexual exploitation, as post-conflict Bosnia and Kosovo became notable destination and transit points for trafficking networks exploiting the presence of international peacekeeping and reconstruction personnel.
- **Codification of a modern legal definition (2000).** The adoption of the Palermo Protocol in 2000 marked a turning point, establishing the first internationally accepted legal definition of trafficking in persons and obliging states to criminalise it, protect victims and cooperate across borders. This Protocol remains the primary legal framework guiding the Committee’s work today.
- **Trafficking by armed and terrorist groups (2014–2017).** The rise of ISIS in Iraq and Syria brought global attention to the systematic use of trafficking by non-state armed actors, most notably the enslavement of Yazidi women and girls beginning in 2014. This period prompted the Security Council to adopt Resolution 2331 (2016) and Resolution 2388 (2017), formally recognising trafficking in conflict as a threat to international peace and security.

Displacement-driven trafficking in recent conflicts

(2022–present). The wars in Ukraine, Sudan and other ongoing conflicts have demonstrated how rapidly trafficking risks emerge during large-scale displacement crises, with

international organisations warning of traffickers exploiting refugees through fraudulent employment schemes, online recruitment and exploitation within displacement settlements.¹¹

Past Actions

The international community has taken numerous actions over the past two decades to combat human trafficking in relation to armed conflict and transnational criminal networks. These efforts have focused on strengthening international legal frameworks, improving cooperation between states, protecting victims and addressing trafficking networks linked to conflict and terrorism.

One of the most significant international agreements addressing human trafficking is the Protocol to Prevent, Suppress and Punish Trafficking in Persons Especially Women and Children, a.k.a the Palermo Protocol. Adopted by the UN General Assembly in 2000 as part of the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organised Crime, the Palermo Protocol established the first internationally accepted definition of human trafficking.¹² It obliged states to criminalise trafficking, protect victims, strengthen border controls and work to cooperate internationally to combat human trafficking networks.¹³ Today, the Palermo Protocol is one of the primary international legal frameworks guiding anti-trafficking policies.¹⁴

In 2010, the United Nations General Assembly adopted the Global Plan of Action to Combat Trafficking in Persons.¹⁵ This plan encouraged member states to coordinate efforts regarding prevention, prosecution and victim protection while also emphasising the importance of addressing the social and economic conditions that contribute to

¹¹ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024 (Vienna: UNODC, 2024) <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/data-and-analysis/glotip.html>

¹² United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2000). Protocol to prevent, suppress and punish trafficking in persons, especially women and children, supplementing the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime. United Nations. <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/human-trafficking/protocol.html>

¹³ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2000). Protocol to prevent, suppress and punish trafficking in persons, especially women and children, supplementing the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime. United Nations. <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/human-trafficking/protocol.html>

¹⁴ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2000). Protocol to prevent, suppress and punish trafficking in persons, especially women and children, supplementing the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime. United Nations. <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/human-trafficking/protocol.html>

¹⁵ United Nations General Assembly. (2010). United Nations Global Plan of Action to Combat Trafficking in Persons (A/RES/64/293, 12 August 2010). United Nations. <https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/687201>

trafficking.¹⁶ The initiative also established the United Nations Voluntary Trust Fund for Victims of Trafficking in Persons, which supports organisations providing assistance to survivors around the world.¹⁷

The United Nations Security Council has increasingly recognised trafficking in persons in conflict and post-conflict situations as a threat to international peace and security. In 2016, the Security Council adopted Resolution 2331, the first resolution specifically linking human trafficking to armed conflict and terrorism.¹⁸ The resolution condemned trafficking by terrorist groups such as ISIS and Boko Haram, recognising that these organisations used trafficking for sexual slavery, forced labour, recruitment and financing operations.¹⁹ Resolution 2331 called upon member states to improve information-sharing, strengthen border security, investigate trafficking linked to terrorism and protect vulnerable populations affected by conflict.²⁰ In 2017, the Security Council adopted Resolution 2388, which expanded international efforts to address trafficking in conflict zones.²¹ The resolution urged member states to improve victim identification, prosecute traffickers more effectively and strengthen cooperation between governments, humanitarian agencies and law enforcement organisations and institutions. It also emphasized the importance of specifically supporting women and children affected by armed conflict and displacement.²²

The UNODC has played a central role in supporting member states through technical and training assistance and research initiatives.²³ UNODC regularly publishes the Global Report on Trafficking in Persons, which provides data and analyses on trafficking trends

¹⁶ United Nations General Assembly. (2010). United Nations Global Plan of Action to Combat Trafficking in Persons (A/RES/64/293, 12 August 2010). United Nations. <https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/687201>

¹⁷ United Nations General Assembly. (2010). United Nations Global Plan of Action to Combat Trafficking in Persons (A/RES/64/293, 12 August 2010). United Nations. <https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/687201>

¹⁸ United Nations Security Council. (2016). Resolution 2331 (S/RES/2331, 20 December 2016). United Nations. <https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/s/res/2331-%282016%29>

¹⁹ United Nations Security Council. (2016). Resolution 2331 (S/RES/2331, 20 December 2016). United Nations. <https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/s/res/2331-%282016%29>

²⁰ United Nations Security Council. (2016). Resolution 2331 (S/RES/2331, 20 December 2016). United Nations. <https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/s/res/2331-%282016%29>

²¹ United Nations Security Council. (2017). Resolution 2388 (S/RES/2388, 21 November 2017). United Nations. <https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/content/sres2388-2017>

²² United Nations Security Council. (2017). Resolution 2388 (S/RES/2388, 21 November 2017). United Nations. <https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/content/sres2388-2017>

²³ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (n.d.). Human trafficking and migrant smuggling. UNODC. <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/human-trafficking/>

worldwide.²⁴ The organisation also assists governments in drafting anti-trafficking legislation, training police and judicial officials to help improve international legal cooperation.²⁵ The IOM has implemented numerous anti-trafficking initiatives in migration passages and conflict-affected regions.²⁶ IOM works closely with governments and humanitarian agencies to identify trafficking victims and provide them with rehabilitation services, working to improve migrant protection systems.²⁷ In conflict settings, IOM has established monitoring systems to track displacement trends and identify populations at heightened risk of exploitation.²⁸

Regional organisations have also developed anti-trafficking frameworks. The EU adopted the EU Anti-Trafficking Directive in 2011, strengthening protections for victims and improving coordination among member states.²⁹ The African Union has supported regional cooperation initiatives focused on trafficking prevention and migration management, while ASEAN has adopted regional conventions addressing trafficking in Southeast Asia.

Human trafficking has also been incorporated into broader international development goals. In 2015, the United Nations included anti-trafficking targets within the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).³⁰ SDG 5 calls for the elimination of violence against women and girls, including trafficking and sexual exploitation.³¹ SDG 8.7 urges states to eradicate forced labour, modern slavery and child trafficking, while SDG 16 focuses on reducing exploitation of and abuse against children.³² Peacekeeping operations and humanitarian missions have increasingly integrated anti-trafficking measures into their mandates. UN agencies and NGOs now provide training for humanitarian workers and peacekeepers to

²⁴ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

²⁵ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (n.d.). Human trafficking and migrant smuggling. UNODC. <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/human-trafficking/>

²⁶ International Organization for Migration. (2024). World Migration Report 2024 (M. McAuliffe & L.A. Oucho, Eds.). IOM. <https://publications.iom.int/books/world-migration-report-2024>

²⁷ International Organization for Migration. (2024). World Migration Report 2024 (M. McAuliffe & L.A. Oucho, Eds.). IOM. <https://publications.iom.int/books/world-migration-report-2024>

²⁸ International Organization for Migration. (n.d.). Displacement Tracking Matrix: National displacement reports. IOM. <https://dtm.iom.int/report-product-series/national-displacement-report>

²⁹ Directive 2011/36/EU of the European Parliament and of the Council of 5 April 2011 on preventing and combating trafficking in human beings and protecting its victims, and replacing Council Framework Decision 2002/629/JHA, OJ L 101, 15.4.2011. <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/eli/dir/2011/36/oj/eng>

³⁰ United Nations General Assembly. (2015). Transforming our world: The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development (A/RES/70/1). United Nations. <https://sdgs.un.org/2030agenda>

³¹ United Nations General Assembly. (2015). Transforming our world: The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development (A/RES/70/1). United Nations. <https://sdgs.un.org/2030agenda>

³² United Nations. (n.d.). Goal 8: Decent work and economic growth — Target 8.7. United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs. <https://sdgs.un.org/goals/goal8>; see also United Nations. (n.d.). Goal 16: Peace, justice and strong institutions — Target 16.2. <https://sdgs.un.org/goals/goal16>

recognize indicators of trafficking and protect vulnerable populations in refugee camps and post-conflict communities.³³ Some missions also cooperate with local authorities to strengthen law enforcement capacity and victim support systems.

Despite these efforts, major challenges remain. Many anti-trafficking initiatives suffer from insufficient funding, inconsistent implementation and limited inter-state coordination.³⁴ Weak governance in conflict zones continues to hinder prosecutions and victim protection efforts. In addition, rapid technological advancements have allowed traffickers to expand online recruitment methods faster than many governments can regulate them.³⁵ Nevertheless, past actions by the UN, regional organisations and individual states have significantly increased international awareness of trafficking in conflict zones. These efforts have helped to establish important legal frameworks, improve international cooperation while recognising trafficking as both a serious humanitarian and security issue.

Current Situation and Statistics

Human trafficking is one of the most prevalent transnational crimes in the world, and conflict and post-conflict zones have become particularly vulnerable to trafficking networks.³⁶ Armed conflict weakens governmental institutions, displaces and destabilises populations and disrupts economies, creating conditions whereby criminal organisations can operate with relatively little consequences.³⁷ In recent years, the international community has observed a considerable increase in trafficking linked to wars and humanitarian crises.³⁸

According to the 2024 Global Report on Trafficking in Persons published by UNODC, global trafficking cases rose significantly after the COVID-19 pandemic, with detected

³³ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

³⁴ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

³⁵ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

³⁶ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

³⁷ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

³⁸ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

victims increasing by around 25% compared to 2019 statistics.³⁹ The report identifies some major factors that are contributing to the vulnerability and exploitation of people, including conflict, poverty, climate disasters and economic instability.⁴⁰ Additionally, women and children continue to represent the majority of trafficking victims, particularly in conflict-affected regions where their legal protections and social support services are limited.⁴¹

Conflict zones create ideal conditions for traffickers because state institutions are often weakened or entirely nonfunctional.⁴² Judicial systems and security officials may become ineffective during and post-conflicts in countries where violence, corruption or political instability has shaken the foundations of governments and their ability to protect their citizens from predators. As a result, traffickers can more easily move their victims across borders, exploiting displaced persons with limited risk of prosecution.⁴³ Refugees and internally displaced persons (IDPs) are especially vulnerable because they often lack proper documentation, stable employment, housing, education and access to legal protections.⁴⁴

The ongoing conflicts in Syria, Sudan, Ukraine, Afghanistan, Libya and the Democratic Republic of the Congo illustrate how war and instability intensify trafficking risks.⁴⁵ Millions of displaced individuals fleeing these conflicts have become targets for forced labour, sexual exploitation, child soldier recruitment, forced marriage and organ trafficking.⁴⁶ In refugee camps and settlements, traffickers often exploit shortages of employment and humanitarian assistance by offering deceptive job opportunities or transportation

³⁹ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024, December 16). UNODC global human trafficking report: Detected victims up 25 per cent as more children are exploited and forced labour cases spike [Press release]. https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/press/releases/2024/December/unodc-global-human-trafficking-report_-detected-victims-up-25-per-cent-as-more-children-are-exploited-and-forced-labour-cases-spike.html

⁴⁰ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁴¹ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁴² United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁴³ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁴⁴ United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees. (2024). Global Trends: Forced Displacement in 2023. UNHCR. <https://www.unhcr.org/sites/default/files/2024-06/global-trends-report-2023.pdf>

⁴⁵ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁴⁶ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

arrangements.⁴⁷ The war in Ukraine has demonstrated how rapidly trafficking risks can emerge during large-scale displacement crises.

Since 2022, millions of refugees (primarily women and children) have crossed into neighbouring European states.⁴⁸ International organisations including the IOM and UNHCR warned early in the conflict that traffickers were targeting vulnerable refugees through fraudulent employment and transportation schemes as well as recruitment tactics via the internet.⁴⁹ Similar patterns have appeared in conflicts across the Middle East and Africa, particularly in regions with weak border controls and high levels of displacement.⁵⁰

Armed groups and terrorist organisations have also been identified as using trafficking as both a weapon and a source of revenue. Groups such as ISIS exploited women and children through forced marriages and recruitment into armed conflict.⁵¹ In several regions of Africa and the Middle East, extremist organisations continue to finance their operations through human trafficking and forced labour. Criminal networks are becoming increasingly cooperative across borders, making trafficking more difficult for individual states to combat independently.⁵²

Technology has also become an important tool in trafficking networks. Traffickers now use social media platforms, encrypted messaging applications and online job advertisements to recruit victims.⁵³ Digital platforms allow criminal networks to operate internationally while concealing their identities and locations. The rise of online scams and internet-enabled forced labour has become particularly alarming in recent years, such

⁴⁷ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁴⁸ United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees. (2024). Global Trends: Forced Displacement in 2023. UNHCR. <https://www.unhcr.org/sites/default/files/2024-06/global-trends-report-2023.pdf>

⁴⁹ UNHCR. (2022, April 12). Statement on risks of trafficking and exploitation facing refugees from Ukraine [Press release]. <https://www.unhcr.org/us/news/press-releases/statement-risks-trafficking-and-exploitation-facing-refugees-ukraine-attributed>; see also UNODC. (2022, March). Targeted by traffickers — Ukrainian refugees at high risk of exploitation [Press release]. <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/press/releases/2022/March/targeted-by-traffickers---ukrainian-refugees-at-high-risk-of-exploitation.html>

⁵⁰ International Organization for Migration. (2024). World Migration Report 2024 (M. McAuliffe & L.A. Oucho, Eds.). IOM. <https://publications.iom.int/books/world-migration-report-2024>

⁵¹ United Nations Human Rights Council. (2016). "They came to destroy": ISIS crimes against the Yazidis (A/HRC/32/CRP.2, 15 June 2016). <https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/hrc/regular-sessions/session32/ress-dec-stat>

⁵² United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁵³ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

as traffickers exploiting displaced populations through false employment schemes.⁵⁴ Despite increased global awareness, many states continue to face serious obstacles in responding effectively to trafficking in conflict and post-conflict zones. In many post-conflict countries, governments lack the financial resources and institutional capacity necessary to identify victims, prosecute traffickers and provide victims with rehabilitation services.⁵⁵ Corruption within law enforcement and border agencies further undermines possible anti-trafficking efforts, and many victims fear reporting crimes because of stigma and distrust of authorities.

Humanitarian agencies have also struggled with funding shortages that affect anti-trafficking programs. In 2025, the IOM warned that major cuts to humanitarian funding threatened the programs assisting vulnerable migrants and trafficking victims worldwide.⁵⁶ Reduced funding risks a further weakening of protection systems within refugee camps, conflict zones and popular passages used by displaced persons and migrants, leaving these already vulnerable populations at even greater risk of exploitation.⁵⁷

International law provides important frameworks for combating trafficking, but its implementation is inconsistent. While many states have ratified the Palermo Protocol, enforcement mechanisms and victim support systems differ greatly from country to country.⁵⁸ Cross-border cooperation is limited in many conflict-affected regions, allowing trafficking networks to more easily exploit legal loopholes and jurisdictional gaps. As conflicts continue to expand and displacement levels are historically high, human trafficking is increasingly recognised not only as a human rights issue, but also a threat to international peace and security.⁵⁹ The challenge facing the international community is to strengthen prevention mechanisms, improve international coordination and support and address the root causes that allow trafficking to flourish in conflict and post-conflict environments.

⁵⁴ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁵⁵ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁵⁶ International Organization for Migration. (2025, March 18). Update on IOM operations amid budget cuts [Statement]. <https://www.iom.int/news/update-iom-operations-amid-budget-cuts>

⁵⁷ International Organization for Migration. (2025, March 18). Update on IOM operations amid budget cuts [Statement]. <https://www.iom.int/news/update-iom-operations-amid-budget-cuts>

⁵⁸ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2024). Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations. https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁵⁹ United Nations Security Council. (2016). Resolution 2331 (S/RES/2331, 20 December 2016). United Nations. <https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/s/res/2331-%282016%29>

Problem Statement

Human trafficking in conflict and post-conflict zones represents a serious threat to international peace, security and human rights. The issue is driven by several factors:

- **Sexual exploitation** (e.g., women and girls forced into prostitution by armed groups or criminal networks)
- **Forced labour slavery** (including children)

(e.g., children forced to work in mines, agriculture, or domestic service and etc.)

Recruitment and use of child soldiers

(e.g., children coerced into fighting, spying, or carrying supplies for armed groups)

Forced marriage

(e.g., girls abducted and forced to marry members of armed groups)

Organ trafficking

e.g., vulnerable people deceived or coerced into having organs removed for illegal sale)

Human trafficking among refugees and IDPs

(e.g., displaced people lured by false promises of jobs or safe passage and then exploited)

Mass displacement

(e.g., families fleeing conflict become separated, making individuals easier targets for traffickers)

Poverty and economic instability

(e.g., people accepting fraudulent job offers due to lack of income)

Limited resources for victims

(e.g., shortages of shelters, legal aid, or healthcare preventing victims from receiving protection and support)

These challenges make it difficult for states to identify victims and prevent trafficking in regions already destabilized by conflict.

Bloc Positions

While many countries agree on major points regarding combatting human trafficking in conflict and post-conflict zones, there are still multiple issues of contention, as different states prioritize different parts of the problem. Consequently, all members of our committee could be divided into several blocs based on their perspectives on the problem at hand.

Conflict-Affected Source States

Countries: Afghanistan, Central African Republic, Chad, Democratic Republic of Congo, Iraq, Libya, Mali, Myanmar, Somalia, South Sudan, Sudan, Syrian Arab Republic, Ukraine, Yemen

For these countries that experience armed conflict or emerge from prolonged instability, human trafficking is often deeply intertwined with the realities of war. The breakdown of governance structures, weakened law enforcement capacities, widespread displacement, and economic collapse create nearly perfect conditions in which trafficking networks can thrive.⁶⁰ Trafficking is not merely a by-product of conflict, it is a tool used by armed actors to sustain military operations and exert control over civilian populations.

For instance, in the DRC, armed groups have long relied on forced labor in mining regions, while children have been recruited as combatants, porters, and informants.⁶¹ Similar trends have been documented in South Sudan, Somalia, and Myanmar, where armed factions have recruited children into military service.⁶² In Iraq and Syria, thousands of

⁶⁰ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024 (Vienna: UNODC, 2024) <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/data-and-analysis/global-report.html>

⁶¹ United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF), "Children recruited by armed forces or armed groups" (UNICEF, updated 2024) <https://www.unicef.org/protection/children-recruited-by-armed-forces>

⁶² Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, Annual Report of the Secretary-General on Children and Armed Conflict (UN Doc A/78/842-S/2024/384, June 2024). Available at <https://childrenandarmedconflict.un.org>

Yazidi women and girls were subjected to systematic sexual slavery by ISIS.⁶³ More recently, the wars in Sudan and Ukraine have generated large-scale displacement, increasing the vulnerability of refugees and IDPs to traffickers operating along migration routes.^{64 65}

Refugee-Hosting and Frontline States

Countries: Jordan, Lebanon, Türkiye, Egypt, Ethiopia, Chad, Pakistan

These countries host significant populations of refugees and IDPs fleeing nearby conflicts. They often function as both destination and transit countries for vulnerable populations. These states are particularly concerned with the trafficking risks faced by refugees, especially women, children, and unaccompanied minors, who may be targeted by traffickers during migration or within refugee camps.⁶⁶ Their primary priorities include greater international burden-sharing, increased humanitarian funding, stronger refugee registration systems, and enhanced cooperation with international organisations. Refugee-hosting and frontline states stress that the international community must do more to support countries that bear the social and economic costs of displacement.⁶⁷

Destination Countries and Human Rights Advocates

Countries: Canada, France, Germany, Norway, Sweden, United Kingdom, United States of America

The countries of this bloc comprise major destination countries for migrants and refugees and generally adopt a human rights-centered approach to combating trafficking. The states emphasize the protection of victims, particularly survivors of sexual exploitation, forced labor, and gender-based violence, while advocating for stronger international

⁶³ United Nations Human Rights Council, "They came to destroy": ISIS Crimes Against the Yazidis, Report of the Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Syrian Arab Republic (UN Doc A/HRC/32/CRP.2, 15 June 2016). This is the landmark 2016 report finding that ISIS committed genocide against the Yazidis. Available at <https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/hrc/regular-sessions/session32/res-dec-stat>

⁶⁴ United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, Global Trends: Forced Displacement in 2023 (Geneva: UNHCR, 2024) <https://www.unhcr.org/global-trends>

⁶⁵ International Organization for Migration, World Migration Report 2024 (Geneva: IOM, 2024) <https://publications.iom.int/books/world-migration-report-2024>

⁶⁶ United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, Global Trends: Forced Displacement in 2023 (2024) <https://www.unhcr.org/sites/default/files/2024-06/global-trends-report-2023.pdf>

⁶⁷ United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, Global Trends: Forced Displacement in 2023 (2024) <https://www.unhcr.org/sites/default/files/2024-06/global-trends-report-2023.pdf>

accountability mechanisms.⁶⁸ Members of this group support such initiatives as international monitoring frameworks, sanctions against trafficking networks, enhanced prosecution of traffickers, and survivor-centered rehabilitation programs. They also push for stronger legal language regarding the responsibilities of governments and armed groups involved in trafficking-related abuses.⁶⁹ Their stance and claims tend to clash with the ones of another bloc that prioritizes sovereignty over international oversight.

Sovereignty-Oriented and Security-Focused States

Countries: China, Russia, India, Pakistan, Egypt, Myanmar

These countries generally support international cooperation against trafficking. However, they maintain that responses should respect state sovereignty and the principle of non-interference in domestic affairs. Rather than emphasizing international monitoring mechanisms, the member states of this group prioritize strengthening national institutions, improving border security and enhancing law enforcement cooperation, and combating terrorism and TOC.⁷⁰ These states are often cautious about solutions and projects that create external accountability structures or impose country-specific scrutiny. Instead, they advocate for technical assistance, information sharing, and nationally led anti-trafficking initiatives.⁷¹

Transit States and Organized Crime-Affected States

Countries: Brazil, Colombia, Mexico, Nigeria, Philippines, United Arab Emirates, Libya, Türkiye

These countries occupy important positions along major migration and trafficking routes and often confront significant challenges posed by TOC networks. They serve as countries of origin, transit, or destination for trafficking victims. The states of this bloc focus mainly on dismantling criminal organizations involved in migrant smuggling, forced

⁶⁸ United Nations Office of Drugs and Crime, Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024 (2024). https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁶⁹ International Labour Organization, Walk Free, and International Organization for Migration, Global Estimates of Modern Slavery: Forced Labour and Forced Marriage (Geneva: ILO, 2022) <https://www.ilo.org/publications/global-l-estimates-modern-slavery-forced-labour-and-forced-marriage-1>

⁷⁰ United Nations Office of Drugs and Crime, Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024 (2024). https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

⁷¹ United Nations General Assembly, United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (res 55/25, 15 November 2000). The UNTOC framework establishes principles of technical assistance and state-led implementation. Available at <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/organized-crime/intro/UNTOC.html>

labor, and sexual exploitation.⁷² The countries of this group support measures such as cross-border intelligence sharing, financial tracking of trafficking profits, enhanced border management, and stronger cooperation between law enforcement agencies.⁷³ Many members also advocate for addressing the economic factors that make individuals vulnerable to exploitation.

Development-Oriented Emerging Powers

Countries: Brazil, India, China, South Africa, Mexico, Nigeria

Although the approaches of these committee countries vary, these states all emphasize the relationship between trafficking and broader socioeconomic challenges. They argue that conflict-related trafficking cannot be addressed exclusively through criminal justice measures and that long-term solutions require tackling poverty, unemployment, inequality, weak institutions, and underdevelopment.⁷⁴ Consequently, they support initiatives focused on economic recovery, education, employment opportunities, and sustainable development as tools for reducing vulnerability to trafficking in post-conflict societies.

General State of Affairs

The biggest divide among countries emerges between human rights-focused destination states and sovereignty-oriented security-focused states. While the former advocate for stronger international accountability and victim protection mechanisms, the latter emphasize national control over implementation. The second divide arises between refugee-hosting countries, which seek greater international assistance, and wealthier donor states, which may prioritize accountability and governance reforms.

Finally, there exists a debate whether the international community should focus primarily on law enforcement and prosecution or on addressing the root causes of trafficking, including conflict, displacement, and economic instability.⁷⁵

⁷² UNODC, Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024 (2024).

⁷³ International Organization for Migration, World Migration Report 2024 (Geneva: IOM, 2024) <https://publications.iom.int/books/world-migration-report-2024>

⁷⁴ International Labour Organization, Walk Free, and International Organization for Migration, Global Estimates of Modern Slavery: Forced Labour and Forced Marriage (Geneva: ILO, 2022) <https://www.ilo.org/publications/global-estimates-modern-slavery-forced-labour-and-forced-marriage-1>

⁷⁵ United Nations Office of Drugs and Crime, Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024 (2024). https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glotip/2024/GLOTIP2024_BOOK.pdf

Key Stakeholders

While states remain the primary actors responsible for preventing and combating human trafficking, they are not the only stakeholders that influence the issue. Given the complex nature of trafficking in conflict and post-conflict settings, a diverse range of international organisations, civil society actors, as well as non-state armed groups shape both the growth of trafficking networks and the effectiveness of efforts to counter them.

International Organisations (IOs)

International organisations play a central role in coordinating anti-trafficking efforts, particularly in contexts where state institutions have been weakened by conflict, displacement, or political instability. The UNODC serves as the leading international body responsible for supporting the implementation of anti-trafficking legislation, strengthening criminal justice systems, as well as facilitating international cooperation against transnational organized crime.⁷⁶ Alongside UNODC, organisations such as the UNHCR, the IOM, and UNICEF focus on protecting vulnerable populations, including refugees, IDPs, and children affected by armed conflict.^{77 78}

Non-Governmental organisations (NGOs)

Beyond direct assistance, IOs contribute to data collection, capacity-building, humanitarian relief, and post-conflict reconstruction initiatives. Their activities are particularly important in situations where trafficking risks increase due to large-scale displacement, weakened governance, and the breakdown of social protection mechanisms.⁷⁹

In many conflict-affected regions, NGOs are among the first actors to identify trafficking risks and provide assistance to vulnerable populations. IOs such as Save the Children, World Vision, and the International Rescue Committee (IRC) deliver humanitarian aid,

⁷⁶ United Nations Office of Drugs and Crime, "Human Trafficking and Migrant Smuggling" (UNODC portal) <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/human-trafficking/index.html>

⁷⁷ United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, Global Trends: Forced Displacement in 2023 (2024) <https://www.unhcr.org/sites/default/files/2024-06/global-trends-report-2023.pdf>

⁷⁸ International Organization for Migration, World Migration Report 2024 (Geneva: IOM, 2024). <https://publications.iom.int/books/world-migration-report-2024>

⁷⁹ International Organization for Migration, World Migration Report 2024 (Geneva: IOM, 2024). <https://publications.iom.int/books/world-migration-report-2024>

child protection services, legal assistance, and psychosocial support to survivors of exploitation and abuse.⁸⁰

In addition to service provision, NGOs play an important advocacy role by documenting human rights violations, raising awareness of trafficking trends, and encouraging governments and international institutions to strengthen protective measures. Their close engagement with local communities often allows them to identify emerging threats more rapidly than state institutions, especially in areas where government authority is limited or absent. Nevertheless, their operations are frequently constrained by funding shortages, security concerns, and restricted access to active conflict zones.⁸¹

Non-State Armed Groups and Terrorist organisations

Non-state armed groups and terrorist organisations represent some of the most significant perpetrators of trafficking in conflict settings. Unlike conventional criminal enterprises, these actors frequently employ trafficking as both a source of revenue and a strategic instrument of warfare. Victims may be subjected to forced labor, sexual slavery, forced marriage, human smuggling, or recruitment into armed service.⁸²

The involvement of such groups highlights the close relationship between trafficking, armed conflict, terrorism, and TOC, demonstrating why anti-trafficking efforts in conflict zones frequently intersect with broader peacebuilding and security objectives.

Guiding Questions - QARMAs

- 1 How can vulnerable populations in conflict and post-conflict zones be identified before they become victims of trafficking?
- 2 What measures can be implemented within refugee camps and displacement settlements to reduce trafficking risks?
- 3 How can the international community address the recruitment and use of child soldiers by armed groups?

⁸⁰ Save the Children, "What We Do: Child Protection" (Save the Children, 2024) <https://www.savethechildren.org.uk/what-we-do>

⁸¹ United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA), Global Humanitarian Overview 2023 (Geneva: OCHA, 2022) <https://www.unocha.org/publications/report/world/global-humanitarian-overview-2023-enaesfr>

⁸² United Nations Human Rights Council, "They came to destroy": ISIS Crimes Against the Yazidis (UN Doc A/HRC/32/CRP.2, 15 June 2016) https://www.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/Documents/HRBodies/HRCouncil/CoISyria/A_HRC_32_CRP.2_en.pdf

- 4 What strategies can be used to combat conflict-related sexual exploitation and sexual slavery?
- 5 How can states strengthen cross-border cooperation to disrupt trafficking networks operating across conflict zones?
- 6 What role should technology play in preventing and detecting human trafficking?
- 7 How can victims and survivors of trafficking be effectively rehabilitated and reintegrated into society?
- 8 How can post-conflict reconstruction efforts reduce the long-term risk of trafficking?
- 9 What actions can be taken to hold traffickers, armed groups, and other perpetrators accountable?
- 10 How can international organizations, national governments, and local communities coordinate their efforts to combat human trafficking more effectively?

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